

encouraging, not all matches have generated that kind of excitement among fans. “There is still a lukewarm feeling about the T20 World Cup amongst cricket fans, but there is still interest from advertisers. Though the India-Pakistan match was on a Sunday, that clash always gets eyeballs, making it a pretty safe investment for brands,” says Sandeep Goyal, MD of advertising agency Rediffusion.

The ninth edition of the ICC Men’s T20 World Cup started barely a week after the marquee Indian Premier League (IPL). With 20 teams across four groups, it will have 55 matches, to be played in the US and West Indies. What remains to be seen is the level of enthusiasm

and, consequently, advertiser interest. “That’s how it manages to pull in big investments each year,” says Chirantan Chandran, who has held leadership roles at marketing firms Mindshare and Dentsu Media and is now Co-founder & CMO of the intercity food delivery firm JustMyRoots. “But, there has been advertiser interest for the T20 World Cup, with sponsorship slots sold across TV, mobile, and connected television,” he adds.

According to Chandran, advertisers are buying time on non-India highlights and India matches to optimise returns. “Plus, with no big tentpole post-elections, advertisers are leveraging the World Cup to maximise reach. The pricing has

According to a statement on May 30, Disney Star had signed deals with 19 sponsors for the T20 World Cup. It has names such as Dream11, Maruti, Parle Products, BPCL, Haier, ICICI Bank, Reliance Retail and Samsung India. “The continued support from renowned brands underscores the immense appeal and significance of this tournament. This diverse group of sponsors demonstrates the enduring popularity of cricket and the strategic importance of sports consumption and innovative content delivery,” said Ajit Varghese, Head of Network (Ad Sales) at Disney Star.

It is gathered that the sponsorship deals are in the ₹15-20 crore band depending on how hard they

PITCH REPORT

1 The ICC T20 World Cup started a week after the Indian Premier League 2024

2 Questions always remain around viewership of non-India matches in a multi-country format

3 After the IPL there was the Lok Sabha polls, before the World Cup. As a result, a large part of media budgets have been spent

4 Disney Star picked up digital and TV rights for the ICC tournaments, including the World Cup and Champions Trophy

from viewers in a year that already had the IPL and the Lok Sabha elections. Moreover, how much more money does an advertiser need to spend in a year?

There is a fundamental difference between the IPL and the World Cup when it comes to viewership interest. In the latter, India matches generate the maximum interest, making them the prime target for advertisers. “Since cricket is the most expensive proposition, a substantial portion of the budget has already gone to the IPL, followed by the elections,” says a marketing head at an FMCG major.

The fact is, the IPL has now set a benchmark for cricket viewer-

ship and, consequently, advertiser interest. “That’s how it manages to pull in big investments each year,” says Chirantan Chandran, who has held leadership roles at marketing firms Mindshare and Dentsu Media and is now Co-founder & CMO of the intercity food delivery firm JustMyRoots. “But, there has been advertiser interest for the T20 World Cup, with sponsorship slots sold across TV, mobile, and connected television,” he adds.

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been aggressive, and the broadcaster is working with advertisers to get better value for their investments.” The other rub is timing. Considering the time zone, some matches are played very late at night in Indian time or very early in the morning. However, most big matches are scheduled in the evening, and they “should have good viewership,” says Chandran. “Also, the US beating Pakistan would have increased interest among smaller teams.”

In August 2022, Disney Star retained the digital television rights to ICC tournaments (including the World Cup and Champions Trophy) for four years by cutting a cheque of \$3 billion.

have been negotiated. In terms of ad rates, a 10-second spot for an advertiser, who has signed deals for all matches, works out to ₹3-3.5 lakh. For an India match, it could hit ₹20-25 lakh. Mayank Shah, Senior Category Head, Parle Products, one of the sponsors, says, “We got a good deal and decided to go for it.”

Disney Star will air the matches on Star Sports for a price but for free on Hotstar, its streaming platform—a decision said to have been provoked by JioCinema. Clearly, a lot depends on high levels of interest from the viewers and the advertisers. **BT**

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